Crop scenario settings: questions for partners

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Why we are asking

The crop outlook's water-management scenarios use our assumptions, not your practice: tell us what farmers at your site actually do, and we will set the scenarios to match.

The platform grows maize, sorghum and bean in the AquaCrop crop model for every member of the seasonal forecast, at six monitored sites. The scenarios grow the same forecast again with one management choice changed, so you can see what a practice is worth this season. Their value depends on the amounts being realistic: 100 mm of irrigation helps a lot on paper, but not if no farmer near you can apply it.

What the scenarios assume now

Four practices are modelled, each on a rain-fed crop sown on the FAO agricultural onset date; the amounts below are ours.

Practice	What the model does now	First result, early maize, 2026 Short Rains
Supplementary irrigation	Waters whenever root-zone moisture falls below 30 % of available water, from sowing to flowering; at most 25 mm a day and 100 mm a season reaching the soil (about 130 mm drawn from a pan or tank)	+0.3 to +4.2 t/ha; up to 28 points less chance of failure
Full irrigation	Keeps root-zone moisture above 70 % all season, no limit on water	Needs 205–414 mm in the season
Mulch	Crop residues cover 50 % of the soil, halving evaporation under them	Up to +1.3 t/ha
Tied ridges or pits	No rain runs off the field: it soaks in where it falls	Up to +0.6 t/ha

Yields are water-limited (no nutrient, pest or disease losses), so they are higher than most smallholder fields reach; the gains between practices are the useful part.

Questions on water

The most useful single answer is how many millimetres (or litres or jerrycans per plot) a typical farmer near your site can put on a crop in one Short Rains season.

1. Do farmers near you irrigate Short Rains crops at all? If so, roughly what share of them?
2. Where does the water come from: river, borehole, pan or dam, roof tank, piped supply?
3. How is it applied: bucket or watering can, hose, furrow, drip kit, sprinkler?
4. How much water can one farmer apply in a season, and on what area? Litres per plot or hours of pumping are fine; we will convert.
5. When do they water: at sowing only, through dry spells, around flowering, or all season?
6. Does the water run short in a dry season, and in which months?

Questions on mulch, ridges and other practices

We assume half the soil covered with residues and ridges that stop all runoff; tell us what is realistic.

1. Do farmers leave or spread crop residues on the field? About what share of the soil do they cover after sowing?
2. Are residues kept for livestock feed instead? If so, how much is usually left on the field?
3. Which water-harvesting practices are used: tied ridges, zai pits, furrows, terraces (fanya juu), half-moons, none?
4. How high are the ridges or how deep the pits, and do they hold the water of a heavy storm or overflow?
5. Is there another practice you would like to see tested, such as a different sowing date, plant spacing, variety or fertiliser rate?

Answers by site

Fill in the row for your site directly in this table; a rough figure is far better than none.

Site	County	Water per season (mm or litres per plot)	Source and method	Residue cover after sowing (%)	Ridges or pits used	Other practice to test
KALRO Kiboko, Makueni Farm	Makueni					
Kapiti Research Station Farm	Machakos					
LiveMo LTD, Memerush	Kajiado					
El Karama Sahiwals Farm	Laikipia					
Genco LTD Maralal Samburu Farm	Samburu					
Genco LTD Tana River Farm	Tana River					

How your answers will be used

Each site's scenarios will be reset to the amounts you give, and the next weekly scenario run will show the result on the platform's Crop outlook tab.

Where practice differs a lot between farmers, we can show two levels (for example 50 mm and 150 mm of water). Answer through the online form linked from the Crop outlook tab of the dashboard (under Management scenarios), or fill in the table above and return it to the person who sent you this note.